East. This is what the two leaders discussed while the agreement between the two countries was still brewing.

Since its establishment, the Mossad has been responsible for establishing secret contacts with countries that have not had diplomatic relations with Israel. It has also used its capabilities to organize clandestine meetings with leaders of countries with which Israel does maintain diplomatic relations but where, because of certain circumstances, both sides preferred the relations to remain secret.

Yitzhak Rabin was in favor of secret diplomacy. It gave him the opportunity to get a better and more direct sense of “friend” and “foe” (to use air force jargon). He enjoyed the secret trips that broke up, if only briefly, his busy routine. He liked to be with the people of the Mossad, who planned the meetings, prepared for them, and carried them out far away from the prying eyes of the media. Particularly top-secret trips were planned in such a way that his absence from the country was not even felt, though in any case there was always a suitable cover story.

The most dramatic visit during my tenure was Rabin’s visit to Indonesia and his meeting with President Suharto in October 1993. The Indonesia visit followed his trip to China, which was the first official visit of an Israeli prime minister to that country. The Mossad was involved both in initiating and in planning for the visit to China, through the Mossad’s channel with the Chinese intelligence service. Because the visit was official and public, the delegation was large and the prime minister’s plane was full of representatives of the Israeli media.

The delegation was housed in the official guest village, a luxurious villa complex in downtown Beijing. Chinese leader Jiang Zemin held a reception and state dinner in honor of the prime minister and his wife, attended by the political and military leaders of China.

In the working meetings with the Chinese prime minister and his team, Rabin instructed me to sit close to him, as part of the Israeli delegation at the table, which led to my being photographed by the local media for the first time since I had begun my term.

I attended a meeting with the head of China’s intelligence and security services and was present at Prime Minister Rabin’s spontaneous lecture on the history of Zionism and the State of Israel, delivered in English and with no prior preparation, to hundreds of Chinese students during a visit to Beijing University. Following the official portion of our visit in Beijing, we